

Folders

We've mentioned that folders are special kinds of files that can hold other files. Let's look inside a folder on the System Disk. Double-click the System folder icon.

Imagine that. *Another* window! This window is titled System and is linked to the System folder icon in the System.Disk window. The new window is probably blocking your view of most of the System.Disk window, so move it out of the way by grabbing the title bar with the mouse pointer and dragging it to an unused portion of the screen.

The System window is linked to the System folder icon in just the same way the System.Disk window is linked to the System.Disk icon. They are, for all practical purposes, the same thing in two different guises. When you're looking at the window titled System, it's just as appropriate to say that you're looking at the System folder, because the window *is* the folder.

We say that the System folder's parent is the System.Disk, because the folder icon is in the System.Disk window. (The System window is also a child of the System.Disk window.) A given folder has only one parent (because it can only be inside one other folder or disk) but it can have many children (because you can put as many folders as you want in a disk or folder.)

In the System window is another set of icons, some of them folders. Browse through them using the scroll bar on the right side of the window.

The idea of folders is an important concept, not only on the Apple IIGS but on most other computers you'll encounter. Imagine trying to find anything on a hard drive where everything is displayed in one window! The System Disk itself contains over 40 files and folders; your hard drive includes all these files and more if you've installed System 6 on it, plus files for all the programs you've installed and your documents. It wouldn't be *too* bad on a floppy disk (even a 3.5" disk), but even viewing files by name or by type won't help you keep things organized when several megabytes' worth of files are all displayed in one window.

That's what folders are for. The System files are organized into folders by their function. For example, fonts (typefaces) go in one folder; desk accessories go in another; sounds go in a third. All of these folders (plus a few others) are stored inside the System folder. So when you want to find the system files, you know just where they are—inside the System folder and the various folders it contains—but you're not faced with all those files every time you open a disk. The system files are grouped together and assigned a name, via the concept of a folder.

You can create your own folders, too. Just use the "New Folder" option on the File menu (or press ⌘-N). A new folder called "Untitled" will appear in the frontmost window. (You may need to scroll the window to find the new folder if the window is crowded.) The folder is selected and ready to rename—just type the name you want to give the folder and press Return.

Most Finder users create one folder on their hard drive for each of their programs, then place each program's files in the folder assigned to it. Additional folders are created to store documents used with these programs. With folders, you can keep yourself organized and avoid spending your valuable time hunting for that one important document.